The Care Project

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will design and begin a sustained care project that requires showing up repeatedly over time, building the understanding that community care is not a single act but an ongoing commitment.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can identify something in our shared space or community that needs care.
- I can commit to an action I will repeat, not just do once.
- I can explain why caring for something over time is different from caring for it once.

MATERIALS

- A community needs scan done in advance: what genuinely needs tending in your setting? (A garden bed, a communal bookshelf, a greeting ritual for younger children, a letter-writing project to elderly residents in a nearby care facility)
- Materials specific to the chosen project
- A care roster posted visibly
- A simple progress documentation wall

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. NEEDS DISCOVERY (8 min): Walk around the setting (or discuss the community). 'What is something that needs looking after here? What would happen if nobody did it?' Generate a list together. This is not rhetorical — let children notice genuinely neglected things.

2. CHOICE AND COMMITMENT (5 min): Vote on one project to adopt as a class. Discuss: 'This isn't something we do once. It's something we do every week, even when it's raining, even when we'd rather play something else. Are we ready for that?'

3. PLANNING (7 min): Together, create a simple plan: What needs doing? Who will do it? When? Draw the roster. Each child signs or marks it — a real commitment.

4. FIRST ACTION (5 min): Begin immediately. Do the first instance of the care project together. 'It won't look different yet — it takes time. But we've started.'

5. ONGOING: Return to the project each week. Document change. Ask: 'Is this better because we're looking after it? What would it look like if we'd stopped?'

EXTENSIONS

- Connect to civic institutions: 'Who looks after our parks? Our streets? Our libraries? What if nobody did?'
- Invite a local council worker, park ranger, or community gardener to visit and share their ongoing care work
- At the end of the program, reflect: 'What changed because we kept showing up?'

ASSESSMENT

- The care roster is an assessment artefact: who shows up consistently?
- Observation: Does the child notice when care has had an effect, without being prompted?
- Learning story: document a moment where a child referenced the project's progress over time

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What did children's level of engagement reveal about their developing sense of responsibility to something beyond themselves?
- How did you handle weeks when children forgot or didn't want to do it? What did that reveal about sustaining commitment?
- What would civic life look like if every adult had this kind of sustained care relationship with their community?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.